

“It’s not exactly prominent or direct, but it’s there”: Understanding Strategies for Sensitive Disclosure Online

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ABSTRACT

Sharing sensitive information online, such as one’s sexual identity or medical information, can be a complex decision. Many people do not share sensitive information out of fear of being stigmatized, yet sharing can be beneficial for a variety of reasons. This study examines two instances of sensitive disclosure within the SAA (same-sex attracted adolescents) community: people revealing their LGBTQ+ status on social media and revealing the use of an anti-HIV medication, pre-exposure prophylaxis (PrEP), on both social media and dating platforms. By examining these two disclosure decisions, we can better understand how designers can support sensitive disclosure. Ultimately, results suggest that designing for disclosure doesn’t mean designing to get people to explicitly disclose, but rather enabling users to subtly communicate sensitive information. Moreover, rationales for disclosing sensitive information play out differently between social media and dating platforms.

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1 INTRODUCTION

Self-presentation online can involve fraught decisions about what to share [19], especially for those with stigmatized identities [17]. People worry about disclosing information on sensitive topics like mental health [14] or sexual identity [4, 11], even when sharing this information might benefit them by decreasing stigma, increasing awareness and relationship satisfaction [24], and fostering community [8]. “Disclosure” has historically been thought of as “what individuals verbally reveal about themselves to others (including thoughts, feelings, and experiences)” [10]. Disclosure can help

develop one’s sense of self and strengthen intimacy with others [10, 20].

Increasingly, people now disclose personal information in an online context [2]. Online platforms today complicate these disclosure decisions with their opaque algorithms, audience uncertainties, and varied affordances [5]. Platforms are simply not designed for sensitive disclosure. People instead often employ strategies to reveal sensitive information in discreet ways [1, 6, 13, 25] that allow for selective visibility [7]. Given the benefits of revealing sensitive information, our motivation is to consider how designers might better support sensitive disclosures.

We sample LGBTQ+ adolescents assigned male at birth, whom we call SAA (same-sex attracted adolescents)¹, as uncertainties around sensitive disclosure can be intensified for this group [9] and they are known to actively manage their self-presentation [3]. Much work on sensitive disclosure has been predominantly focused on adult populations [1, 23, 25] yet SAA can be multiply marginalized by their age and their sexual and/or gender identity. It is thus important to study those who might be intersectionally stigmatized [23].

We specifically look at how SAA disclose their LGBTQ+ status, which can be stigmatizing [4] but beneficial to reveal [8, 24]. We also look at SAA attitudes toward disclosing medical information, specifically pre-exposure prophylaxis (PrEP), a daily HIV prevention pill recently approved for adolescent use by the US Food and Drug Administration. When PrEP was made available to adults, some who used it were seen in the gay community as hypersexual or lacking the wherewithal to use extant HIV prevention techniques such as condoms [12]. Among adolescents, we might expect similar stigma given that PrEP usage implies not only LGBTQ+ status, but also sexual activity. At the same time, sharing one’s PrEP use can spread awareness and reduce stigma [26].

Online spaces, such as social media and LGBTQ+ dating platforms such as Grindr², can be influential for raising PrEP awareness [21], but these spaces have distinct audiences and norms. For example, on LGBTQ+ dating platforms, LGBTQ+ status is often assumed

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¹We use the abbreviation SAA (same-sex attracted adolescents) to group individuals according to their sexual identity expressions although we do recognize the problematic nature of grouping individuals. We chose not to label them as “gay” as not all of them identify in this way. MSM (men who have sex with men) is typically used in public health literature, but given the majority of our participants had not had sex, a sexual identity grouping seemed more appropriate than a behavioral label. While we refer to participants as SAA, they did identify with one or more identities under the LGBTQ+ umbrella.

²There is substantial evidence [22] that people under age 18 use Grindr, even though it is a policy violation for them to do so.

which can make revealing sensitive information potentially more comfortable. Yet at the same time, people on dating platforms are often interacting with people they have not met before and might not trust whereas on social media people tend to interact with others they have met before. As such, it may be useful to compare attitudes toward PrEP disclosure between social media and dating platforms. Understanding how adolescents disclose sensitive information can inform broader research to support sensitive disclosure online.

In this study, we analyze open-ended survey responses about SAA strategies and attitudes for sharing both their LGBTQ+ status and their PrEP status so as to gain nuanced insights into their decision-making. Therefore, our research questions are:

RQ1: What are the strategies SAA use to reveal their LGBTQ+ status on social media?

RQ2: What are SAA attitudes towards disclosing their PrEP status online? What differences arise between social media and dating platforms?

2 METHODS

Our data set is from a larger study conducted in 2019 [5] of 215 SAA males living in the US, aged 15 to 18. Participants were given a survey which included questions about social media and dating app use, if and how participants are 'out' online, and their knowledge of and attitudes toward PrEP. For this study, responses to 4 open-ended items were hand-coded by two independent coders.

3 ANALYSIS

A content coding scheme (see below) was developed by iteratively reading responses, listing emergent themes, and discussing. To ensure reliability, coding began with a training phase in which sub-samples of responses were independently coded iteratively until agreement was better than 80% for all categories. This was followed by coding the entire response set.

For RQ1, responses were coded to one question that asked SAA about how they thought their LGBTQ+ identity could be discerned by others on social media (N=105). Only those participants who thought their LGBTQ+ status could be discerned answered this question. Coding categories for this question were first identified as **explicit** or **implicit**. To be coded as **explicit**, the respondent had to use the word "gay", or clearly indicate that they were openly expressing their LGBTQ+ identity on social media. The **implicit** category was broken down into *implicit affiliate*: posting things to associate themselves with the LGBTQ+ community, *implicit visual*: posting visual and/or symbolic representations of the identity, and *implicit behavioral*: the respondents' manners of expression and the cues they thought they were giving off in their profiles.

For RQ2, responses to three questions were coded: 1) why they are unlikely to post about PrEP on social media (N=155), 2) why they are unlikely to post about PrEP on dating platforms (N=54), and 3) why they are likely to post about PrEP on dating platforms (N=123). Respondents only saw questions 1 and 2 if they indicated in the survey that they would not disclose PrEP use on social media/dating platforms and saw question 3 if they would disclose PrEP on dating platforms. While the survey included information about what PrEP is, the majority of SAA were not actually using PrEP, and thus these three questions were asked to discern their attitudes around

hypothetically disclosing PrEP status. Coding categories for these questions included: **Norms of social media/dating platforms**: what respondents perceived as standard practice and fitting to post on social media or dating platforms; **audience management**: catering activity to a particular target audience on a platform; **reputation**: fear or worry concerning others' perceptions; **perceived relevance**: if posting PrEP status is deemed by respondents as suitable in that situation; and **inadvertent outing**: not wanting to post about PrEP as it would reveal one's LGBTQ+ identity.

Responses that referenced more than one strategy/category were coded with all relevant codes. Percentages do not add up to 100% as a small number of items were coded in multiple categories. Additionally, responses that were not intelligible or did not fit a category are excluded from the total response count.

4 FINDINGS AND DISCUSSION

RQ1: What are the strategies SAA use to reveal their LGBTQ+ status on social media?

We found that out of the 105 respondents who answered this question, 35% disclosed their identity through explicit cues and 72% disclosed their LGBTQ+ identity through implicit cues. The three implicit strategies were to reveal one's LGBTQ+ status through affiliate (27%), visual (14%), or behavioral (31%) means. These different strategies allowed for ambiguity in how SAA revealed their LGBTQ+ status and to hide from those that might be homophobic. One respondent, who used an affiliate strategy stated of this strategy: "This way, I am protecting myself from the homophobic population who would most likely be ignorant of popular LGBT people. At the same time, other LGBTQ+ people will know that I am gay from mutual followers/following." His ambiguous cues helped protect him from some, while outing himself to others. Another respondent affiliates with the LGBTQ+ community by being "very vocal about queer rights" which doesn't explicitly implicate him as LGBTQ+ as he could just be perceived as an ally or supporter. The ambiguities of social media obscure the reasons behind why someone shares LGBTQ+ information in that it could be to show general support, or because they identify as part of the community [1].

One respondent, who primarily uses a visual strategy, explained regarding his LGBTQ+ flag in his bio: "...Sure, it's not exactly prominent or direct, but it's there and people can interpret it as they wish." He is aware his signaling is subtle, but this allows him to reveal sensitive information in a way he feels comfortable. This confirms past work which found that people use subtle cues to convey sensitive information [6, 25]. Indirect disclosures may relate to Goffman's notions around saving "face" [18] in that SAA could plausibly deny their LGBTQ+ status if they wanted to. Those who used implicit behavioral strategies felt people could tell they had an LGBTQ+ status from the pictures of their boyfriends, the "gay vibe" of their accounts, or other cues. Clearly, the ambiguities of online platforms can be helpful. Affiliate, visual, and behavioral strategies were all used by SAA in order to reveal their LGBTQ+ status in a comfortable way.

RQ2: What are SAA attitudes towards disclosing their PrEP status online? What differences arise between social media and dating platforms?

We found that 155 respondents said they would not reveal their PrEP status on social media. The reasons for not sharing were the norms of social media (43%), the perceived relevance of the information (26%), reputational concerns (17%), inadvertent outing (14%), and audience management (5%). Clearly, the social context of a platform is important [5]. Even when SAA did want to reveal their PrEP status, they felt it would not fit in with social media norms. Instead, one respondent explained he would rather: "...text some of [his] friends about it." Disclosing in more intimate one-on-one interactions was preferred [25]. While messaging in private can be beneficial, this is unlikely to reduce reputational and stigma concerns around sensitive disclosure.

Unlike sharing LGBTQ+ status which could be done implicitly, adolescents felt sharing PrEP had to either be done explicitly or was not to be mentioned on social media at all. One respondent, in emphasizing the importance of social context, explained, "...if I was given a platform that was more focused on gay teen health or somewhat more open to that community I would most certainly share my experience." On social media, however, despite people seeing value in the information, most participants said they were unlikely to disclose. On dating platforms, only 54 respondents gave reasons for why they wouldn't disclose PrEP. Respondents worried about its perceived relevance (50%), the norms of dating platforms (31%), and reputational concerns (22%). For example one respondent, who had reputational concerns, said, "It really does make you seem like a fuckboy or someone who's too active." This is similar to stigma adults faced in that sharing PrEP makes people perceive them as hypersexual [12].

In general, SAA were more open to disclosing PrEP on dating platforms where it is less taboo and more normative to discuss subjects related to sexual health. Indeed, 123 respondents gave rationales for why they would disclose PrEP on dating platforms. 93% of SAA said they would disclose PrEP on dating platforms as they felt it was relevant and 7% thought it fit the norms of dating platforms. Given the lack of differentiation between the codes, we further distinguished the rationales for wanting to share PrEP on dating platforms. The majority of respondents felt that PrEP was relevant to disclose in order to communicate their sexual health and responsibility to others. Respondents offered rationales such as to "display safety", to show they are "protected and responsible", to demonstrate they "care about sexual health" and that they are "clean." Thus sharing PrEP on dating platforms was actually seen to enhance reputation and indicate sexual responsibility. Some respondents felt that sharing PrEP status on dating platforms was "a must" in that it was the right thing to do to "protect others", and raise awareness about PrEP in "teaching someone about it" who might not know. A few respondents also felt it was relevant to disclose as people might be more likely to reach out to them. One respondent with this rationale explained: "I believe it will increase my chances of landing a guy and it could be helpful."

5 IMPLICATIONS

Ultimately, online spaces can be very important in learning about LGBTQ+ related information [15] and increasing PrEP knowledge, particularly among adolescents [21]. SAA were using affiliate, visual, and behavioral strategies to reveal their LGBTQ+ status and

if designers can find ways to promote these strategies, people will likely feel more comfortable in disclosing sensitive information. Ultimately, ambiguity can be a resource for design [16].

Features such as Facebook's "Interested in" option or Grindr's HIV and PrEP status profile fields are likely too explicit for a lot of people to fill out. The importance of ambiguity is particularly crucial on social media, where people may be more reluctant to share sensitive information. Designers should continue to support subtle disclosure such as promoting use of ephemeral stories [5] and/or awareness campaigns that educate people about different ways of revealing sensitive information. These results show that sensitive disclosure is not solely a design challenge, but a socio-technical problem in that we need to design to support subtlety but also render disclosure normatively acceptable.

6 CONCLUSION

This study analyzed how SAA share sensitive information online, as exemplified by the sharing of their LGBTQ+ status and use of the anti-HIV medication, PrEP. In terms of disclosing their LGBTQ+ status, most respondents did not want to out themselves explicitly online, but rather preferred to do so implicitly. In terms of sharing PrEP use, rationales played out differently between social media and dating platforms. Respondents were more likely to share sensitive information deemed either relevant or normative to the context, meaning they preferred to share on dating platforms over social media. Consequently, designing for the possibility of disclosing sensitive information in ambiguous fashions is particularly important on social media. Rather than designing for explicit disclosure, designers should therefore design for subtle disclosures that can happen in a multitude of implicit ways.

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